CODEALPHA ROBOTICS & AUTOMATION INTERNSHIP

Task 4: PLC-Based Automation

PLC Architecture, Control Logic and Industrial Automation

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Branch: Electronics and Communication Engineering (ECE), 5th Semester

Internship: CodeAlpha – Robotics & Automation Internship

Internship Dates: 01/10/2026 – 31/10/2026

1. Abstract

A Programmable Logic Controller (PLC) is an industrial digital controller used to automate machines and processes. PLCs receive signals from sensors and switches, execute a control program, and operate outputs such as motors, valves, lamps and actuators. This report explains PLC architecture, operation, inputs and outputs, ladder logic, timers and counters, HMI/SCADA integration, and a conceptual conveyor-belt automation example.

2. Introduction

Industrial automation reduces repetitive manual operations and improves consistency, productivity and process control. PLCs are widely used because they are programmable, designed for industrial environments and can handle digital and analog signals. A PLC can be reprogrammed when the required process sequence changes.

3. What is a PLC?

A Programmable Logic Controller is a rugged industrial computer designed to monitor inputs, execute a user program and control outputs. The program defines how the machine should respond to sensor conditions, operator commands, timers, counters and other logic.

4. Main Components of a PLC

A typical PLC system includes a CPU, power supply, input modules, output modules, communication interfaces and programming software. The CPU executes the control program. Input modules receive signals from field devices, while output modules send commands to actuators and other equipment.

5. PLC Inputs and Outputs

Digital inputs can come from push buttons, proximity sensors, limit switches and photoelectric sensors. Analog inputs can represent variables such as temperature, pressure or level. Digital outputs can control contactors, solenoid valves, lamps and relays. Analog outputs can provide control signals to suitable drives or process equipment.

6. PLC Operating Cycle

A PLC normally works through a repeating scan cycle. It reads input states, executes the user program, updates outputs and performs communication or diagnostic tasks as required. The scan repeats continuously. Response time depends on the controller, program and system configuration.

7. Ladder Logic

Ladder Logic is a common PLC programming language based on contacts and coils. Input conditions are represented by contacts and output actions by coils. Logical operations such as AND and OR can be represented through series and parallel arrangements. Timers, counters, comparison instructions and other functions can be added for more complex sequences.

8. Conceptual Conveyor Automation Example

A conveyor system can be automated using a PLC, start and stop push buttons, an object-detection sensor, a motor contactor or suitable motor-control device, and an emergency-stop circuit. When the operator presses Start and the safety conditions are satisfied, the PLC can command the conveyor motor

to run. When an object is detected, the program can perform a predefined action such as stopping the conveyor for a set time or activating another actuator. The Stop command or a fault condition stops the process.

9. Example Control Sequence

1. System is powered and initialized.
2. Safety and emergency-stop conditions are checked.
3. Start push button is pressed.
4. PLC energizes the conveyor motor output.
5. Sensor detects an object on the conveyor.
6. PLC executes the programmed response using suitable logic or timer instructions.
7. The sequence repeats until Stop is pressed or a fault/safety condition occurs.

10. Timers and Counters

Timers are useful when an output must remain active or inactive for a specified period. Counters can count detected objects, completed cycles or other events. For example, a PLC could count products passing a sensor and stop the conveyor after a predefined batch quantity.

11. HMI and SCADA Integration

A Human-Machine Interface (HMI) can allow an operator to view machine status, start or stop permitted functions, enter setpoints and view alarms. Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition (SCADA) systems can provide higher-level monitoring, data logging and visualization across multiple machines or processes.

12. Communication

Modern PLCs can communicate with drives, HMIs, remote I/O and supervisory systems using industrial communication technologies. The selected network depends on the equipment, required performance, interoperability and plant architecture.

13. Applications

PLC-based automation is used in conveyor systems, packaging, assembly lines, bottling plants, material handling, water treatment, process control, machine tools, building automation and many other industrial systems.

14. Advantages

PLCs provide reliable control, easy program modification, fast response, industrial communication capabilities, diagnostics and the ability to integrate many sensors and actuators. They can reduce repetitive manual work and improve process consistency.

15. Limitations and Challenges

PLC systems require appropriate programming and commissioning skills. Hardware, sensors, actuators, wiring and engineering can add cost. Incorrect logic or configuration can cause unsafe machine behavior. Network failures, sensor faults and power problems also need to be considered during system design.

16. Safety Considerations

Safety must be designed independently and appropriately for the machine risk. Emergency stops, protective interlocks, overload protection, safe motor isolation and fault monitoring may be required depending on the application. A normal PLC control program should not be assumed to provide all required safety functions.

17. Future Scope

PLC-based systems are increasingly integrated with Industrial IoT, edge computing, data analytics, robotics, HMI/SCADA platforms and manufacturing systems. These integrations can provide improved monitoring, predictive maintenance and production analysis while retaining reliable local control.

18. Conclusion

PLC-based automation provides a practical method for controlling industrial machines through programmable logic. By combining sensors, PLC logic, actuators, timers, counters and operator interfaces, processes such as conveyor handling can be automated in a structured way. Proper engineering, testing and safety design are essential before deploying a PLC system on real equipment.

19. References

1. IEC 61131-3, Programmable Controllers – Programming Languages. 2. NIST resources on industrial/operational technology security. 3. Siemens, Rockwell Automation and Schneider Electric PLC technical documentation and educational resources. 4. CodeAlpha Robotics & Automation Internship – Task 4.